PROJECT REPORT

AirtCraft: Building a B2B Art Marketplace for India

From a B.Tech thesis on an artisanal marketplace to a quote-based platform for corporate and design buyers

481	8	4	15%
survey respondents	platforms reviewed	role-based dashboards	commission model

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2024 to 2026
Thesis, pivot and launch

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Abstract

AirtCraft is a B2B marketplace that connects corporates and interior designers with verified Indian artists trained at art and design institutes. Buyers use it for corporate gifting, office and hospitality art, and commissioned work. The project developed in two stages.

Version 1 (B.Tech thesis, 2024) planned a broad two-sided marketplace for all Indian artists and buyers. Pilot surveys of 214 artists and 267 buyers found that 68.6% of artists were open to selling online. Corporate gifting and interior designers already accounted for almost 40% of artists' customers. An alpha test delivered 7 products in Bhubaneswar, but missing payments, uneven quality and weak delivery made a consumer marketplace hard to run.

Version 2 (AirtCraft) narrowed the scope to business buyers after a second study. Each deal is priced by quote, covering bulk discounts, GST, timeline and payment terms, instead of a fixed list price. Designers get project workspaces with client sign-off, corporates get curated collections and branded gifting, and negotiation stays on the platform so the commission is protected. The platform went live as a working web app. The startup is now on hold because every team member has taken up a full-time job, so this report presents AirtCraft as a completed startup attempt.

PART 1

The research that led to the pivot

Version 1 was submitted as a B.Tech thesis at IIT Kharagpur in April 2024. It set out to build one marketplace for all Indian artists and all buyers, from individual gift buyers to corporates. The surveys and the alpha test below pointed us towards business buyers. The competitor review in this part was added for this report and uses current public data.

1 Problem statement

The Indian fine arts and handicrafts sector suffers from low pay, limited market access and weak online representation. This puts both artists' livelihoods and the craft heritage at risk. The project set out to close the gap between art, commerce and social impact, in line with UN SDG 1 (No Poverty) and SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth).

The thesis rated five challenges on a 10-point impact scale. Scores are approximate.

CHALLENGE	IMPACT (OF 10)	WHAT IT MEANS FOR ARTISTS
Artist unemployment	8	Skilled artisans cannot find steady work
Fair compensation	8	Pay is too low to sustain their practice
Skill development	8	Few chances to upskill for modern market demand
Market access	7.5	Hard to reach target customers and markets
Digital presence	7	Low online visibility and weak digital marketing

2 Objectives

Based on these challenges, the platform had to provide:

1. A single platform that connects artists directly with buyers
2. Fair pricing mechanisms that pay artists properly
3. Skill development and training programmes
4. Digital tools and support for building an online presence
5. Market expansion, both within India and abroad
6. Streamlined logistics and payments

3 Research methodology

We ran a two-wave pilot study with two separate Google Forms surveys, so we could see the market from both the artists' and the buyers' side.

SURVEY	PARTICIPANTS	KEY QUESTIONS
Artist survey	214	Sales channels and how well they work; customer segments; interest in digital platforms; preferred mediums; barriers to reaching buyers
Buyer survey	267	Demographics; how often they buy; barriers to buying; interest in art as gifts; what drives the purchase decision

4 Key findings

The demand is there, but artists still sell mostly offline. 68.6% of artists are open to digital platforms, yet online channels bring in only 16.4% of their sales. Among buyers, 73% said they would or might buy art as a gift.

Business buyers already make up almost 40% of artists' customers



Figure 1. Share of artists' customers by segment, artist survey (n = 214). Highlighted segments are the ones AirtCraft later served.

Artists

- Sales channels: art fairs and exhibitions lead with 24.3% of sales; online platforms account for 16.4%.
- Mediums: folk art 20%, digital art 19%, oil painting 18%, sculpture 17%, watercolour 16%.

Buyers

- Gift interest: 43.8% definitely interested, 29.2% maybe, 27% not interested.
- Art types considered: contemporary (85 responses), folk (83), home decor (79), textiles (78), sculpture (76).
- Gift-buying frequency: several times a year 45.7%, monthly 22.8%, annually 15%, several times a month 14.6%, less often 1.9%.

Delivery and trust are the biggest barriers for buyers



Figure 2. Share of buyers naming each barrier, buyer survey (n = 267). Buyers could name more than one.

The version 1 design answered these barriers with zone-based logistics, product verification and curated, occasion-based collections.

5 Market and competitive analysis

Most existing platforms either list Indian crafts in a huge general catalogue (Amazon, Flipkart, Etsy) or curate a small range themselves (iTokri, Gaatha). None combines artist-owned listings with business tools for artists and dedicated channels for corporate, hospitality and interior design buyers. That gap is where we position ourselves.

We compared eight platforms in three groups: mass marketplaces with artisan programmes, global art and handmade marketplaces, and Indian craft specialists. Fees are the latest figures we could find in public sources, with the year shown, and programme terms change often.

PLATFORM	MODEL	FEE TO THE ARTIST	SUPPORT FOR ARTISTS	GAP WE CAN FILL
Amazon Karigar	Artisan storefront inside Amazon.in; 8 lakh+ weavers, 270+ art forms (2020)	Referral fee capped at 8% or less, by category (2020)	Training, account managers, product photoshoots, homepage marketing	Crafts get lost in a mass catalogue; no authenticity checks, no portfolio or career tools
Flipkart Samarth	Artisan programme inside Flipkart; 6 lakh+ artisans and weavers (2020)	0% for the first 6 months, then 5% (2020)	Free cataloguing, first-month ad credits, onboarding training	Same mass-catalogue problem; support stops after onboarding
Etsy	Global handmade marketplace; artists run their own shops	6.5% transaction fee, payment processing, 0.29% India regulatory fee and $0.20 per listing; 12–15% offsite ads fee (2026)	Shop analytics and ad tools; no hands-on onboarding	Fees in dollars, international shipping and returns put off small Indian artisans
Saatchi Art	Curated global marketplace for original art	40% of the sale price on originals; artist ships the work (2025)	Global audience, curator picks	Very high commission; only fine art, with no crafts, gifting or corporate buyers
iTokri	Buys stock in bulk from 10,000+ artisan families and resells it; about ₹27 crore revenue (2022)	None directly; iTokri earns the retail margin	Artisans need no online skills at all	Artists don't control price or customer relationships; buying all stock upfront limits growth
Gaatha	Curated craft store, plus craft research and design consultancy	Not disclosed; products are designed or selected by Gaatha	Craft documentation, storytelling, design help	Small curated range; no self-serve tools for artists
GoCoop	Marketplace for 275+ handloom cooperatives in 10 states; about 70% B2C and 30% B2B (2016–17)	5–15% commission	Quality checks, packing, shipping; payment within 3 days	Handloom only, and it serves cooperatives rather than individual artists

PLATFORM	MODEL	FEE TO THE ARTIST	SUPPORT FOR ARTISTS	GAP WE CAN FILL
Craftsvilla	Started as a handicraft marketplace, then moved into ethnic fashion; consumer business wound down around 2019	No longer trading	No longer trading	A warning: it drifted away from crafts and burned through cash

Only GoCoop and Saatchi Art share our corner, each in a narrow niche

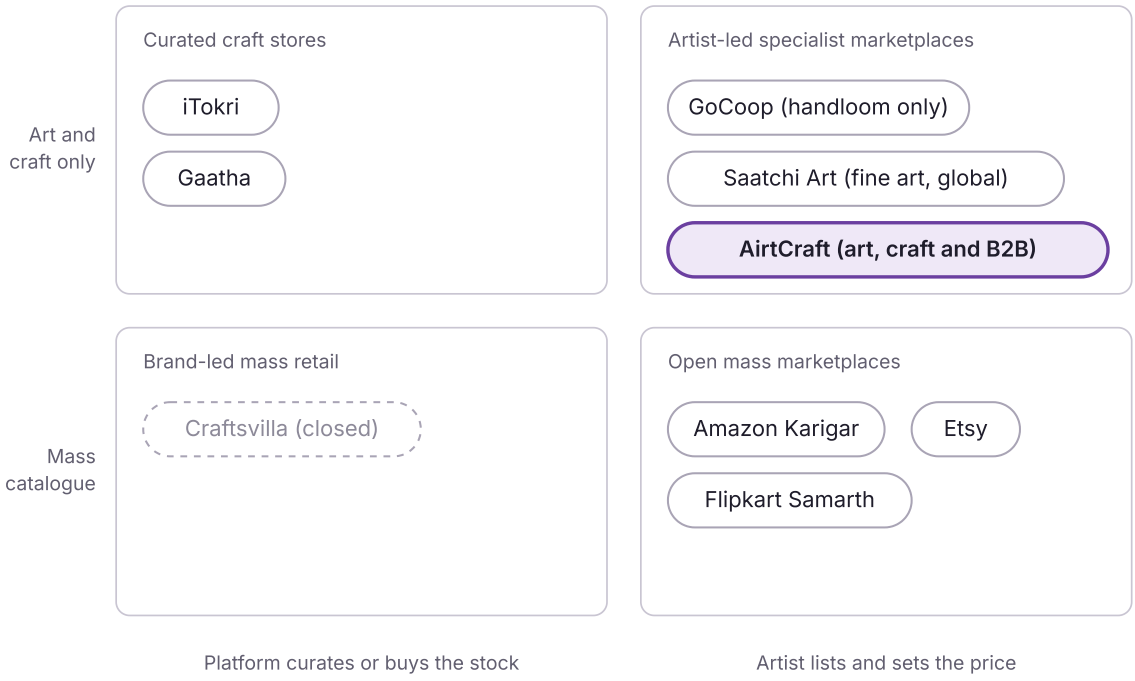


Figure 3. Platforms placed by who controls listings and how wide their range is. Placement is our own assessment.

What this means for our design

1. Our 10–15% commission falls within GoCoop's 5–15% range and is close to Etsy's total fees. It is above the subsidised Amazon and Flipkart rates but far below Saatchi Art's 40%. In return, artists get tools that mass marketplaces don't offer.
2. Business buyers are underserved. Corporate gifting (19.2%) and interior designers (20.1%) already make up almost 40% of artists' customers, yet only GoCoop has a meaningful B2B channel, and it is limited to handloom.
3. Delivery (40%) and authenticity (38%) were buyers' top barriers. The mass marketplaces don't verify crafts, which supports our verification process and zone-based delivery.
4. iTokri shows that artisans value not having to manage selling, but they give up pricing and customer relationships. Our artist tools aim for the same ease while letting artists keep both.
5. Craftsvilla's move into fashion is the risk to avoid. Our roadmap stays on art and craft and grows region by region.

6 Version 1 design: an open two-sided marketplace

Artists list and manage their work on one side, and four customer segments buy on the other: individual gift buyers, small and medium hospitality businesses, interior designers and corporates.

Marketplace (buyer side)

- Listings organised by type, style and price, with search and personalised recommendations
- Secure payments by card, digital wallet or bank transfer
- Customer reviews and ratings to build trust
- Dedicated sections for personalised gifting (custom messages, gift wrapping, occasion collections), corporates (bulk orders, branded artworks, dedicated support) and interior designers (artist collaboration, themed collections, project tracking)

Artist admin website and app

MODULE	WHAT IT DOES	AVAILABLE TO
Dashboard	Live sales and engagement figures, recent activity, alerts, configurable widgets	All
User management	Profile editing, two-factor login	All
Content management	Upload images, video and 3D models; organise collections; publish a blog	All
Sales and orders	Order tracking from payment to delivery, inventory alerts	All
Analytics	Revenue reports, customer insights	All
Support and helpdesk	Tickets, knowledge base, live chat	All
Customisation	Layouts, themes, modular widgets	All
Marketing tools	Social scheduling, discount codes, affiliate programmes	Premium
CRM	Contact database, messaging, review management, surveys	Enterprise
Portfolio website	Drag-and-drop templates that work on any device	Premium

The platform also planned career tools for artists: an AI-matched job board, skill assessments, a resume builder and networking forums.

Operations

- Onboarding: identity checks, skill assessment, review of work samples and background checks, followed by training and performance monitoring.
- Quality control: material, workmanship and authenticity checks, plus ratings from customers and experts.
- Logistics: India split into North, South, East and West zones. Each order goes to an artist chosen by distance to the buyer, specialisation, current workload and partner-institution affiliation. Partner couriers handle delivery and returns.

- Customer service: automated ticketing, a self-service FAQ, separate support teams for artists and buyers, and live order tracking.

7 Version 1 revenue model

Version 1 planned four revenue streams. The marketplace commission was the main one and grows with sales, so the platform only does well when its artists do.

STREAM	HOW IT CHARGES	WHY IT MATTERS
Marketplace commission	10–15% of each sale, depending on category and volume	Main income source; grows with transaction volume
Artist subscriptions	Three tiers: Free for students, Professional for working artists, Enterprise for studios and galleries	Steady, predictable income
Corporate solutions	Custom pricing for corporate gifting, interior projects and collaborations with well-known artists	High-value contracts that also bring artists their most profitable work
Value-added services	Fees for promotional packages, featured listings and one-to-one consulting	Personalised support that improves retention

8 Version 1 roadmap and alpha test

By April 2024, Phase 1 was complete. A four-person team ran the research, built the marketplace website and delivered 7 products to customers in Bhubaneswar through WhatsApp as an alpha test. The team was Saswat Dash and Abhinaw Anand (co-founders), Sandnya Patil (marketing) and Akshat Srivastav (development).

1. Phase 1, completed: market research, scope and objectives, team formation, marketplace design and build, alpha test.
2. Phase 2, planned for the next 5 months: legal documentation, the artist admin website and app, core features, pilot onboarding of artists in a few regions, functional and user acceptance testing.
3. Phase 3: onboarding artists nationwide, then marketing to bring in users after launch.
4. Phase 4: post-launch operations and scaling.

Planned marketing channels were search (SEO around art, craft and regional keywords), social and content marketing, events such as exhibitions, fairs and workshops, and partnerships with art-supply companies, educational institutions, cultural organisations and tourism boards.

9 Legal framework

- Company structure: a partnership firm at first, with name reservation and incorporation filings through the MCA portal.
- GST: registration becomes mandatory above ₹40 lakh annual turnover (₹20 lakh in special-category states), with regular GSTR-1 and GSTR-3B filings.
- Intellectual property: trademark registration and copyright protection.

- Contracts: artist agreements, supplier and vendor contracts, confidentiality agreements and employee contracts.

10 Social impact

The thesis mapped the platform to four UN Sustainable Development Goals and scored each on a 10-point scale.

SDG	IMPACT AREA	SCORE	HOW THE PLATFORM CONTRIBUTES
SDG 8: Decent work and economic growth	Job creation	9.5	Steady work for artisans, entrepreneurship, formalising informal art businesses
SDG 1: No poverty	Artist income	9.0	Direct sales without intermediaries, more income sources, digital payments
SDG 4: Quality education	Skill development	8.5	Structured learning, continuing professional development, peer learning
SDG 12: Responsible consumption	Sustainable crafts	8.0	Eco-friendly materials and methods, less supply-chain waste

11 Challenges faced

1. Payment gateway: without a GST number and legal paperwork, we could not integrate payments.
2. Onboarding: without proper payments and compliance, it was harder to attract artists, keep them and get their products listed.
3. Quality: without quality checks or feedback loops, product quality was inconsistent.
4. Distribution: without a delivery network, orders were delayed and fewer customers bought again.
5. Trust: incomplete legal compliance made users, partners and artists trust the platform less.

12 What version 1 taught us

> Version 1 showed real demand, but a consumer marketplace for every kind of artist and buyer was too broad to run well with a small team. Three lessons shaped AirtCraft:
>
> 1. **Business buyers were already there.** Corporate gifting and interior designers made up almost 40% of artists' customers.
> 2. **The hard problems shrink with bigger orders.** Payments, quality checks, delivery and trust are easier to manage across fewer, larger orders than across many small consumer sales.
> 3. **Nobody serves this gap.** No competitor offered corporate and design buyers access to individual artists with a managed buying process.

PART 2

AirtCraft, the B2B marketplace

After the thesis, we kept going with the project as a startup. We ran a second study and narrowed the scope to a B2B marketplace, AirtCraft. It connects corporates and interior designers with verified artists who are alumni of art and design institutes.

13 Why we narrowed to B2B

The version 1 research already pointed towards business buyers.

- Demand: corporate gifting (19.2%) and interior designers (20.1%) made up almost 40% of artists' existing customers.
- Competition: of the eight platforms reviewed in Part 1, none serves corporate and design buyers with tools built for artists. GoCoop's B2B channel covers only handloom.
- Operations: the challenges from the alpha test (no payment gateway, inconsistent quality, weak delivery) are easier to handle with fewer, larger orders.

Second study: user interviews

To test this, we interviewed three groups: HR and administration teams who handle corporate gifting and office setup, artists, and architects and interior designers. Comparing B2C, B2B and a hybrid model, we reached four conclusions.

1. **Higher margins.** Corporate orders come in bulk, and producing in bulk lowers the cost per piece. B2B therefore earns a better margin than B2C or a hybrid of the two.
2. **Simpler operations.** Orders from one company are large and similar to each other, which means far fewer quality, packaging and delivery problems than many one-off consumer orders.
3. **Easier to sustain.** Steady repeat business from a small number of clients is a safer base for an early-stage startup than chasing consumer demand.
4. **B2C as a later step.** The plan was to build the business on B2B first, then expand back into a full B2B and B2C marketplace after two to four years.

14 Target customers

AirtCraft serves two kinds of buyers. On the supply side, artists are verified alumni of art and design institutes.

BUYER	WHAT THEY BUY	HOW THE PLATFORM SERVES THEM
Corporates (HR, procurement, admin, founders)	Gifts for clients, employees and events; office and boardroom art; bulk prints; custom commissions	Curated collections, bulk quotes, logo branding, GST invoices, team accounts
Interior designers and architects (offices, hotels, hospitality)	Art for specific projects, matched to the client's colour palette	Project workspaces, moodboards, client approvals, white-glove installation

At sign-up, a corporate buyer picks an estimated annual art budget from five bands: under ₹1 lakh, ₹1–5 lakh, ₹5–20 lakh, ₹20–50 lakh and over ₹50 lakh. The catalogue filters artworks into three price bands: under ₹50,000, ₹50,000–2,00,000 and above ₹2,00,000. It is grouped into four curated collections:

- Executive Suite: refined landscapes and portraits for private offices
- Boardroom Series: abstract and contemporary statement pieces
- Lobby and Reception: large-scale works for first impressions
- Corporate Gifts: smaller works for client appreciation

15 How a deal flows

In version 1, buyers paid listed prices. In AirtCraft, every corporate purchase starts as a quote request on a specific artwork, with the quantity and any customisation notes. An order only exists once the buyer accepts a quote. Designer projects join the same pipeline when the client signs off on a selection.

Every deal starts as a quote and becomes an order only on acceptance

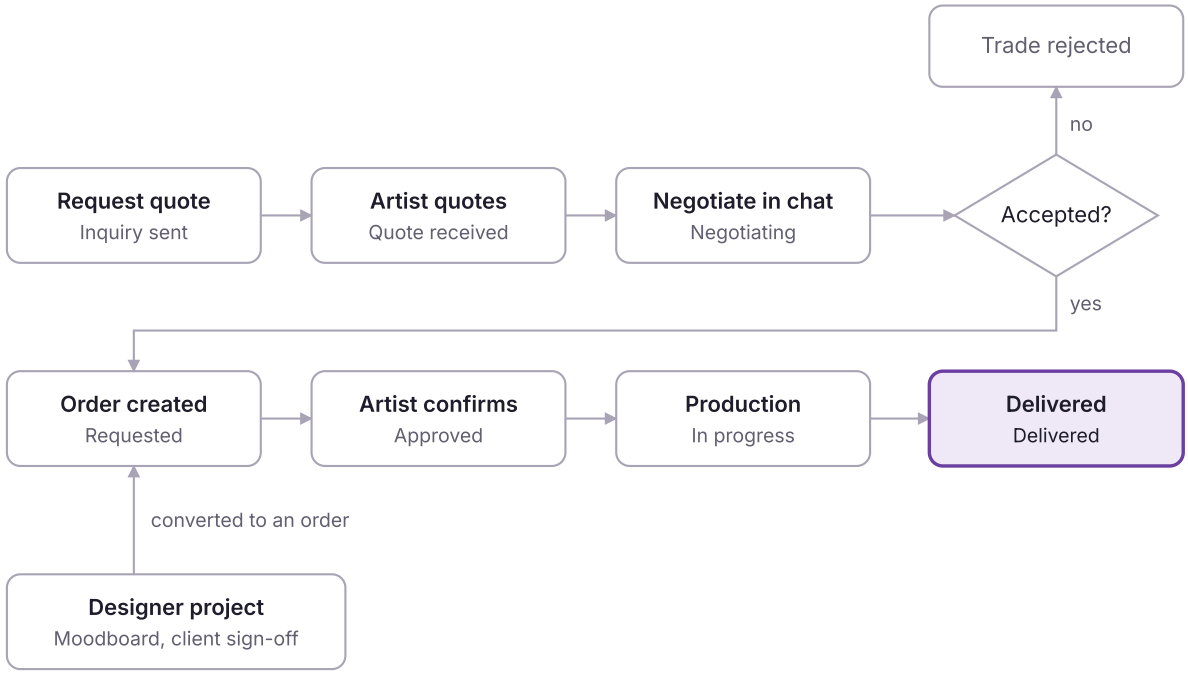


Figure 4. AirtCraft deal flow. The status stored on the platform is shown under each step.

16 Features by user

Each of the four user types gets its own dashboard. Buyers can switch prices between INR and USD.

USER	MAIN TOOLS
Corporate buyer	Corporate catalogue with category and budget filters; quote requests with quantity and customisation notes; inquiry inbox; order tracking and history; invoices; brand asset library for branded gifts; team members; saved delivery addresses; company profile with GSTIN; notification settings
Interior designer	Project workspaces with client name, theme and budget; moodboards shared with clients; approve or reject each artwork version; invite artists; convert final selections into an order; project-level invoicing and delivery
Artist	Portfolio manager and artwork upload; commission pipeline board (new inquiries, in progress, ready to ship); quote builder; in-platform chat with buyers; orders; revenue and profile-view stats; marketing hub
Admin	Platform overview (active artists, orders, revenue); invite collaborators; artist verification; login secured by a one-time password

17 Pricing and revenue

AirtCraft replaces fixed list prices with a quote for each deal. The artist builds the quote on the platform, and the system calculates the total:

$$\text{Total} = \text{base price} \times \text{quantity} \times (1 - \text{bulk discount}) \times (1 + \text{GST}) + \text{shipping}$$

Each quote also states a production timeline (1 week, 2 weeks, 1 month or 2 months), payment terms (100% upfront, 50% advance and 50% on delivery, or Net 30 days), inclusions such as framing and installation, and a validity date. The catalogue tells buyers that bulk discounts may apply on orders of more than 10 units. When the buyer accepts a quote, the platform generates an order number and the order starts at Requested.

AirtCraft earns a 15% commission on each order, its only revenue stream at launch. Paid artist subscriptions, carried over from version 1, were planned for a later stage once the artist base was large enough.

18 Financial projections (hypothetical)

These scenarios are hypothetical, since AirtCraft has no trading history to forecast from. In the base case, 120 business clients spending about ₹3.5 lakh a year would generate ₹4.2 crore in orders by year 3. That would earn AirtCraft ₹63 lakh in commission and pay artists ₹3.57 crore.

$$\text{Revenue} = \text{active business clients} \times \text{annual spend per client} \times 15\%$$

SCENARIO	CLIENTS Y1	Y2	Y3	SPEND PER CLIENT Y1	Y2	Y3
Conservative	15	35	60	₹1.5L	₹1.75L	₹2L
Base	25	60	120	₹2.5L	₹3L	₹3.5L
Optimistic	40	100	200	₹4L	₹5L	₹6L

Clients are corporates and design firms. The spend figures are set within the budget bands buyers choose at sign-up: the base case sits inside the ₹1–5 lakh band, and the optimistic case moves into the ₹5–20 lakh band as repeat clients add office art to their gifting orders.

AirtCraft commission revenue by year and scenario

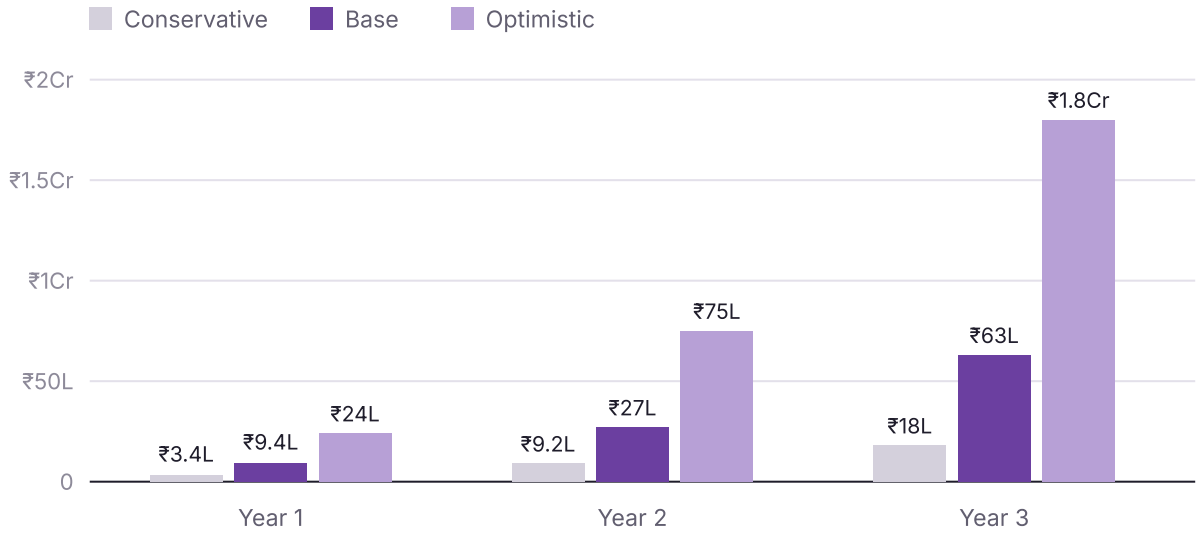


Figure 5. Projected commission revenue at 15% of order value.

SCENARIO	ORDER VALUE Y1	Y2	Y3	REVENUE Y3	PAID TO ARTISTS Y3
Conservative	₹22.5L	₹61.3L	₹1.2Cr	₹18L	₹1.02Cr
Base	₹62.5L	₹1.8Cr	₹4.2Cr	₹63L	₹3.57Cr
Optimistic	₹1.6Cr	₹5Cr	₹12Cr	₹1.8Cr	₹10.2Cr

Order values exclude GST and shipping charges. Artists receive the remaining 85% of each order. The model leaves out subscription revenue and operating costs, so it shows the size of the opportunity. It does not estimate profit or a break-even date.

19 Trust and compliance

AirtCraft tackles the trust problems from version 1 in the product itself.

- Curated supply: artists submit a portfolio and only join after a curator review and verification.
- Negotiation stays on the platform: chat messages containing an email address or phone number are blocked, and the artist sees a compliance warning. This protects both sides and stops deals moving off the platform, where the commission would be lost.

- B2B invoicing: buyers must give a GSTIN when signing up, and quotes add GST, so every order can be billed with a valid tax invoice.
- Secure access: admin login uses an emailed one-time password, and each user role sees only its own dashboard.

20 Technology and current status

AirtCraft was built as a web app using Next.js 14, TypeScript and Tailwind CSS. Data is stored in Firebase Firestore, and the data model has 13 entities, including users, artist, corporate and designer profiles, artworks, inquiries, orders, projects and invoices. Login uses JWT tokens with role-based access, inputs are checked with Zod, and transactional emails go through Nodemailer.

Built

Public site and marketplace, sign-up and onboarding for each role, the corporate dashboard, artist inquiries and quoting, the order pipeline, designer projects and the admin console.

Not built

Online payment and artist payouts (the gap that also blocked version 1), full-text search, full analytics dashboards and a mobile app.

AirtCraft went live but is not operating now. The founding team has moved into full-time jobs, and the startup is on hold. It did not publish traction figures, so none are reported here.

Conclusion

AirtCraft keeps the goal of version 1, giving Indian artists fair access to buyers who value their work. It narrows that goal to the market that pays for quality and needs a managed process: corporates and interior designers. Quote-based deals, curated artists and negotiation that stays on the platform address the pricing and trust problems the research found.

The startup is on hold because the team has taken up full-time jobs. If it restarts, the first task would be online payment and artist payouts, the same problem that held back version 1. After that comes the planned return to a combined B2B and B2C marketplace.

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